

Chapter 64_1: Compliance

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu had actually accepted the gift, Ning Fuyi felt an inexplicable joy well up in her heart, along with surprise. This was just a method she had thought of on a whim - she never expected Chu Qingqiu to accept it so readily.

"Not that hard to coax after all." Ning Fuyi's gaze swept over the jade bracelet Chu Qingqiu held in her hand.

A mortal jade bracelet without any immortal power enchantments was actually far from worthy of her. But to put it another way, no matter how ordinary a piece of jewelry was, when worn on that jade-white wrist, it would be elevated to elegance, like a sparrow transforming into a phoenix upon landing on a branch¹.

Chu Qingqiu no longer sat with a cold face. She rose gracefully, turned to face Qiu Yi: "If there's a next time, you can find yourself another master. This venerable doesn't want a disobedient disciple."

Words spoken in anger were merciless, but to Qiu Yi's ears they sounded like heavenly music. Seeing that Chu Qingqiu was willing to let this matter pass, she immediately fell to her knees with a thud, raising three fingers in oath: "Heaven above as my witness, this disciple is loyal only to Master. From now on, this disciple will never act rashly again. If I violate this oath, may I be struck by lightning!"

Chu Qingqiu glanced at her again, waved her hand to lift her up, and frowned: "There's no need for such a vicious oath. Just keep it in your heart."

Then she strode upstairs to her room. After hearing the sound of the door closing firmly, Qiu Yi finally went limp, sitting down in the grand chair where Chu Qingqiu had been, drenched in sweat.

She wearily lifted her eyelids to look at Ning Fuyi, muttering: "Master really does listen to you. What kind of spell did you cast on her to make someone as detached as floating clouds and wild cranes² not only care about you everywhere, but also comply with you everywhere?"

"Just a coincidence." Ning Fuyi lowered her eyes nonchalantly, pulled over a chair to sit down, and poured herself tea. "Where do you see that she complies with me everywhere?"

"Am I Master's disciple or are you her disciple? I follow her around every day. Don't I know more than you, an outsider?" Qiu Yi glared.

Seeing that Qiu Yi had been led by the nose again, Ning Fuyi continued to provoke her, shaking her head repeatedly: "These days I've been with her every day, while you've been meditating in the sect all the time. Where have you seen more than me?"

"How are you so impossible to reason with!" Qiu Yi was indeed annoyed. She slammed the table and stood up, then remembering Chu Qingqiu's instructions, quickly lightened her movements, frowning and whispering her complaints.

"No matter how I said I wanted to go out to subdue demons, she wouldn't agree. But as soon as you say you want to go out, she can abandon all sect affairs and go to Qi Kingdom with you. Doesn't that count? And that time you went to Tongchuan³, when she learned you were in danger, she rushed to Tongchuan overnight. I've never seen her so concerned about any disciple before."

"Oh, you mean those things." Ning Fuyi leaned back lazily, picked up her teacup and drank. "The Venerable already said she looks after me because of Ning Changfeng's instructions. They were close friends, so it's normal to look after a friend's child."

Seeing that Ning Fuyi refused to believe anything, Qiu Yi's stubborn streak emerged. She slapped the table: "You ungrateful fool! Looking after? Have you ever seen someone look after another's child to the point of being severely injured yet still not forgetting to save your life!"

Having said this, Qiu Yi suddenly realized what she had done. Her words immediately cut off, and she covered her mouth with both hands. Her eyes, still red and swollen from crying earlier, suddenly widened.

Ning Fuyi keenly caught her words, and the hand holding her teacup paused: "So, you know when Chu Qingqiu's old injury was acquired?"

Qiu Yi quickly waved her hands: "I never said I knew."

She corrected herself quickly, but her eyes betrayed her.

Since her rebirth, the Chu Qingqiu that Ning Fuyi had seen was already injured. However, at that time she was full of hatred and wouldn't have taken Chu Qingqiu's injuries to heart.

This meant that Chu Qingqiu's old injury existed before her rebirth. But in her previous life, Chu Qingqiu had clearly remained that invincible Divine Venerable until the very end. With her power at the time, if Chu Qingqiu had old injuries, she definitely would have noticed.

So either Chu Qingqiu had healed her old injury later, or the Chu Qingqiu of this life had experienced something completely different from the previous life? Before her rebirth?

Ning Fuyi suddenly felt her mind was tangled like a ball of yarn, and her heart felt like thousands of ants were gnawing at it. She urgently wanted to know the truth.

Qiu Yi knew she had misspoken and caused trouble again. Not daring to say more, she pushed her chair aside and ran toward her room. Ning Fuyi raised her hand to summon her divine sword, which spun with wind and embedded in the door frame, blocking Qiu Yi's path.

She waved her hand again, and the door suddenly slammed shut. Qiu Yi closed her eyes, resigned to her fate, and turned around.

"Speak clearly, or I'll go ask the Venerable myself right now." Ning Fuyi said.

Having just been punished, Qiu Yi naturally didn't dare let Chu Qingqiu know she had misspoken again. For a moment, she wavered back and forth.

"Since you've already let it slip, what harm is there in saying a few more words? Besides, I already learned from Jiang Li that the Venerable has injuries. I'm just curious about when these injuries were acquired. What can't you say?" Ning Fuyi began to coax persuasively.

Qiu Yi thought about it and felt Ning Fuyi made sense. After all, the injury matter was exposed by the medical immortal, not her. What was she afraid of?

So she spoke: "I don't know the exact time either. I only know the first episode was two days before the former sect master's incident. That day everything was normal - Master finished teaching me martial arts and returned to her chambers."

"But when Master called for me again, she had already vomited blood all over the floor. I was panic-stricken and didn't know who to ask for help, so I could only seek the former sect master, and that's how Master was saved."

"My mother?" Ning Fuyi was surprised. "Then what did they say? Did they mention how this injury was acquired?"

Qiu Yi shook her head: "I was blocked outside the stone door and didn't hear anything."

Two days before... This timing was too close. For the first time, Ning Fuyi felt her head was like a ball of mush, impossible to sort through no matter how she tried.

"Then before being injured, where had Chu Qingqiu gone? What had she done?"

"Nowhere." Qiu Yi shook her head. "At that time, Master had been in seclusion for several years and hadn't even left Purple Mist Peak⁴. I was also curious about the reason, but Master wouldn't even let me mention it."

Seeing she could get no more information, Ning Fuyi finally reached out and pulled out her divine sword. Qiu Yi, seeing that Ning Fuyi had finally stopped questioning, quickly lifted her skirt and left like a whirlwind, afraid that running too slowly would give her another handle to grab.

Ning Fuyi stood alone in the darkness, utterly perplexed.

Tonight's moon only stayed for a short while before being blocked by continuous dark clouds. Rivers and seas fell into the silence of a dark and windy night⁵. Mountains full of trees rustled, and even the mice that foraged at night retreated to their holes.

Before Cloud Deep Hall, only cups and plates remained in disarray. Some disciples had been carried back to Pearl Light Pavilion⁶ and Precious Qi Studio⁷ by immortal attendants, while others simply slept sprawled on the ground, snoring one after another.

A crow flew from somewhere, cawing as it fluttered over the crowd. The mournful cawing woke several people, and the awakened disciples muttered irritably in their sleep.

Someone opened her eyes in a corner. The ends of her long hair were soaked with wine, dripping water. Two bright yellow hairpins had fallen from her hair. She opened her drunk eyes and struggled to pick up the two mud-stained hairpins.

She pinched the hairpins with her jade fingers, her eyes flashing with resentment and disgust. She raised her hand and threw the pins down the mountain, then swayed to her feet.

She had never liked drinking, always feeling that alcohol disturbed one's mind. She had never looked favorably upon those who drowned their sorrows in wine, thinking they had no ability and only used intoxication to escape reality.

But tonight, when she saw Ning Fuyi achieve merit again and be loved by so many people, the dissatisfaction and hatred in her heart had nowhere to be resolved. For a moment, she could only drink, getting herself thoroughly drunk, thinking that way she could forget her pain. Who knew she would sober up so quickly?

Even alcohol worked against her. Why did others fall asleep when they drank, while she became increasingly clear-headed, clearly feeling the jealousy and hatred in her heart?

Li Chao'an grabbed a wine jar from the table and smashed it hard against the ground. The crisp sound of shattering porcelain cut through the silent night, causing several disciples to talk in their sleep.

She smashed several in a row until her hand was cut by porcelain shards. Only the stinging pain made the stifling anger in her heart dissipate somewhat.

She had to return to Pearl Light Pavilion. She didn't want to associate with these drunkards.

Li Chao'an stumbled over the people lying crosswise on the ground, walking down the mountain along the small path shaded by tree shadows, nearly sliding down the slope several times.

Her entire family had been slaughtered by enemies, leaving only her alone and destitute. Her life only improved after meeting Ning Changfeng, but she didn't thank Ning Changfeng because her parents had saved Ning Changfeng's life - this was what Ning Changfeng should do.

From the moment Ning Changfeng brought her back to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, she had envied Ning Fuyi. At first, she only envied her, envied that she could possess all of Ning Changfeng's love. But later, when she wanted more and more, envy became bone-deep jealousy.

Ning Changfeng would get angry at Ning Fuyi and would coax Ning Fuyi to be happy, but with her, it was a different attitude. Though gentle and kind, there was always a faint distance that could never be crossed. This sense of distance made her painfully mad.

She couldn't understand why a waste who couldn't even cultivate could easily possess everything she wanted. So she could only practice desperately. Fortunately, she was good material, possessing cultivation that Ning Fuyi could never catch up to, and the favoritism of everyone except Ning Changfeng.

This sense of superiority over Ning Fuyi could somewhat offset the crazy jealousy in her heart.

However, things changed after Ning Changfeng's death. The Ning Fuyi who could once be easily trampled into the mud was no longer weak and bullied. Ning Fuyi surpassed her time and again, winning back the favoritism that originally belonged to her, as if the treasures once held in her hands were being taken away bit by bit.

She hated it so much, she was going mad with hatred!

Footnotes:

¹ **Sparrow transforming into a phoenix upon landing on a branch (飞上枝头变凤凰)** - Chinese idiom meaning someone of humble origins achieving great success or status

² **Floating clouds and wild cranes (闲云野鹤)** - Chinese idiom describing someone who is detached from worldly affairs, free-spirited and unrestrained

³ **Tongchuan (铜川)** - A location mentioned earlier in the story where Ning Fuyi went on a mission

⁴ **Purple Mist Peak (紫霞峰)** - The mountain peak where Chu Qingqiu's residence is located

⁵ **Dark and windy night (月黑风高)** - Chinese idiom often used to describe a night suitable for nefarious activities

⁶ **Pearl Light Pavilion (珠光阁)** - One of the residential buildings at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate

⁷ **Precious Qi Studio (宝气斋)** - Another residential building at the sect